Chapter 1 – The Beginning of the End

Lyra had stopped measuring days.

Morning, night — it all blended into the same dull grey. Sometimes she'd open her eyes and the sun would already be high, but her body refused to move. Her head hurt, her chest hurt, even her arms ached from doing nothing.

It wasn't sadness anymore. It was weight.

It lived in her bones, in the small spaces between her ribs. Breathing was a job. Existing was another one.

People told her, "you just need to get out more."

She smiled, said "yeah, maybe," then went home and crawled back under the blanket that smelled like old tears and coconut oil.

When her dad died, she'd promised herself she'd keep the house alive with laughter for him. But laughter didn't come easy anymore. It came in quick flashes — a joke from her sister, a silly argument with her mom — then disappeared the moment she closed her bedroom door.

That's when everything quieted again.

The fake smiles slid off. The noise in her head came back. She'd sit on the floor with her back to the wall, tracing circles on the tile, wondering when she stopped feeling human.

She was tired of pretending.

Her phone buzzed again. She didn't even have to look. It was him.

Caspian.

The boy from high school.

The quiet one who sat by the window in Physics, always scribbling something in his notebook that wasn't notes. He wore glasses that always slid down his nose, and his voice — when he used it — sounded like he was still testing it out.

Back then, Lyra barely noticed him beyond the small smiles they exchanged. He wasn't the loud type or the "notice me" type. He was just… there. Soft. Easy to miss if you weren't looking.

But now, somehow, he was the only person who kept showing up.

It started small — texts after years of silence.

"Hey, random question… do you still listen to coldplay, you used to write on all your notebooks?"

She didn't answer.

Then another one.

“Okay, awkward. That probably sounded weird. Hope you’re okay.”

A week later, another:

“I saw a cat that looked like it’s been through the same semester we did senior year.”

She snorted despite herself.

He was still weird. Quiet, awkwardly funny, but weird.

Over the next few weeks, the messages didn’t stop. They weren’t flirty or heavy — just warm. Thoughtful. Tiny reminders that someone out there still remembered her.

Then one afternoon, when the walls felt too close, she texted back:

“Yeah, I still listen to them.”

His reply came a minute later:

“Good. I knew you had good taste.”

That’s how it started — no big confession, no fate, just a thread between two tired souls.

When Caspian showed up at her door weeks later, she almost didn’t recognize him.

He’d grown into himself — same gentle eyes behind new frames, same quiet energy, but steadier. He still looked like he belonged in a library more than anywhere else.

He was holding two coffees. “I didn’t know what you liked, so I guessed,” he said, voice soft like he was afraid of scaring her.

Lyra blinked. “You just… showed up?”

He smiled, a small nervous one. “You didn’t block me. I took that as permission.”

She almost laughed. “You’re ridiculous.”

“Yeah,” he said, “but I brought caffeine.”

She let him in.

He talked more than she expected. Not loud — just steady. Calm. The kind of talking that didn't need attention, only space. He filled the silence with small stories about his day, his coworkers, a documentary he half-understood but was excited about anyway.

Lyra sat there listening. For once, she didn't feel the need to perform, to crack jokes or keep things alive.

Usually, she was the talker, the one who filled every awkward pause. But with Caspian, she didn't have to.

She liked the sound of his voice — not because of what he said, but because it was warm. Safe.

Sometimes he'd say something that made her laugh, then blush like he hadn't meant to.

And that laugh — God, it scared her.

It reminded her she could still feel something.

When he left, he didn't try to hug her or say anything dramatic. He just smiled and said, "You'll be okay, you know."

She wanted to believe him.

Days passed. He kept checking in. Calls, voice notes, more coffee.

Sometimes she ignored him. Sometimes she didn't.

And slowly, it became routine — him showing up, her pretending she didn't like it, both of them knowing she did.

He'd ramble while she listened. He told her about the time he accidentally joined a cooking class full of retirees, about the books he never finished, about his fear of birds (which she found hilarious).

One day she said, "You realize you talk way more than me now, right?"

He looked embarrassed. "Is that bad?"

She shook her head. "No… it's nice. I like hearing you talk."

It was the truth. Listening to him made her body unclench a little. The ache was still there, but quieter.

One evening, when the light outside was fading orange, she finally said it.

"I'm not okay, Caspian. I'm really not."

He nodded. "I know."

"I'm… kind of losing my mind."

He adjusted his glasses and gave her a half-smile. "Then I'll hold the pieces until you find them."

She wanted to cry and laugh all at once.

Later that night, she texted him:

“You still want me? Even like this?”

His reply came almost immediately:

“Especially like this.”

She stared at it for a long time before answering:

“Fine. Let’s do this. But don’t say I didn’t warn you.”

He sent one more message:

“Deal. I’m not scared of storms.”

She placed her phone on her chest and closed her eyes. For the first time in months, the silence in her room didn’t feel like punishment.

That’s how it began.

Not with passion or promises.

Just two people — one learning to breathe again, one patient enough to sit beside her until she did.

Five weeks.

Lyra had counted the days, though she wouldn't admit it. Every morning she woke to the soft hum of Caspian moving around the apartment, making coffee, adjusting the blinds, leaving little notes — *"don't forget to eat"* or *"you're still here. that's good enough."*

She liked that he was gentle, quiet, careful. But part of her hated how calm he could be when she was a storm. She was messy, unpredictable, broken, and he never flinched. That terrified her.

So she tried to overcompensate.

At first, it was small things — teasing touches, brushing against him when he didn't expect it, dressing in ways she thought would make him look twice. She laughed a little too loudly at his jokes, leaned in a little too close. Anything to make him want her so he wouldn't see the cracks underneath.

Caspian noticed. Always. But he didn't lecture. He didn't rush. He just… slowed down, moved carefully around her. He adjusted his glasses, half-smiled, and said, "You don't have to do all that."

Caspian wasn't just her soft landing. He was practical too. Bills, job applications, small errands she couldn't handle — he quietly took them on. He printed resumes for her, emailed contacts, even searched for part-time positions she might tolerate. He made lists of budgets and savings like it was second nature, like he didn't realize how heavy the gesture felt on her heart.

She watched him one evening, headphones on, carefully typing out an application for a remote job she hated the idea of trying. His tongue peeked out in concentration. She wanted to laugh, but instead she leaned over and kissed his cheek.

"You're insane," he said softly.

"Am I?" she asked, voice low, half-smiling. "Maybe I just want you to notice me."

He looked at her like she had two heads. "I notice you every day. Not like this, not like that. All of you."

And that made her want to disappear and lean closer at the same time.

The days weren't always smooth. Sometimes the weight of her depression spilled into their moments. A bad morning could turn into a snappy afternoon. A small fight could blow up for hours. She'd apologize, he'd forgive, and then she'd guilt herself for leaning on him so much.

One evening, a misunderstanding with a job application she had sent caused a cascade of stress — a phone call from a distant relative, a mistake at the bank, bills piling up. Lyra snapped at Caspian, blaming him for her own failures, yelling words she didn't mean.

He stepped back. Quietly, gently, but enough to leave a gap between them she hadn't seen before.

"I…" he said, voice low, hesitant. "I need a little space. Not forever. Just… to breathe."

Lyra froze. The apartment felt huge, empty. She wanted to apologize, to chase him, to explain that she was broken and that's why she acted out — but she also knew she had pushed him farther than he could ignore.

That night, she lay in the dark, listening to the soft hum of the city, and realized: for all his patience, for all his care, for all his quiet love, Caspian wasn't invincible. He had limits. And maybe… maybe she didn't know how to be loved the right way.

He did come back. Not right away — a few days passed in silence, the kind that eats at your chest — but he came back. Still the same man: steady, warm, the kind who'd fix a broken mug instead of throwing it away. But there was something new in his eyes — a carefulness that hadn't been there before.

That night, he finally spoke, his voice low but firm, cutting through the quiet.

"Lyra… I can't keep doing this the way we've been doing it." He ran a hand through his hair, staring at the floor. "Every time you snap, every time you push me away, it… it hurts. It's exhausting. I can't pretend it doesn't."

She swallowed hard, words caught in her throat.

"You need to… let me help you," he continued, eyes finally meeting hers. "Not halfway, not when it's convenient. All the way. Or I can't stay. I can't keep pretending that I can fix what keeps breaking."

He paused, his jaw tight, breathing shallow. "I'm not giving you an ultimatum. I'm giving you the truth. You have to meet me somewhere, Lyra. Otherwise… this — us — it won't survive."

She wanted to argue, to cry, to say she'd try. But the weight in his eyes — the careful, heavy way he was standing there — stopped her. She could see exactly how much he was holding back, how much he already carried, how much he was risking just by staying.

With the rules came the weight — insecurity, doubt, and a quiet heaviness that pressed on her chest. She started picking at things that didn't need fixing. Questioning small silences. Misreading his pauses. If he didn't text right back, she'd assume he'd stopped caring. If he smiled a little less, she'd push harder, make jokes that cut too deep, say things she didn't mean just to see if he'd still stay.

He always did. But every time, a little less of him stayed behind.

He wasn't bubbly anymore. The light in him dimmed. His laughter became shorter, his shoulders tenser. He still wanted her — she could feel it in the way he'd linger beside her, in the way his hand would almost reach for hers before pulling back. He wanted her with everything in him. But she could see what loving her was doing to him.

And she couldn't stand it.

So she told herself that maybe the kindest thing to do was to make him stop trying.

Dinner time came — their one unchanging ritual. They ate, side by side, watching their show in silence. Normally, after the credits, he'd pull her close, kiss her hair, maybe turn the quiet into something softer, something physical. But that night, he broke the pattern.

He stood, stacked his plate, washed it without a word. And instead of reaching for her like he always did, he grabbed his keys.

"No movie?" she asked, voice small.

He hesitated. Just for a moment. Enough for her to think he might turn back. But he didn't.

"Not tonight," he said softly. Then he left.

The door clicked shut. The TV light flickered over her face — too bright, too harsh. She didn't move. And then it hit her all at once. A sob that didn't need sound, a cry that came from somewhere too deep to reach.

She knew, right then, she'd done it. She'd broken him.
And in the same breath, she finally understood — she loved him.
Not the idea of him, not the comfort. *Him.*
And it was too late.